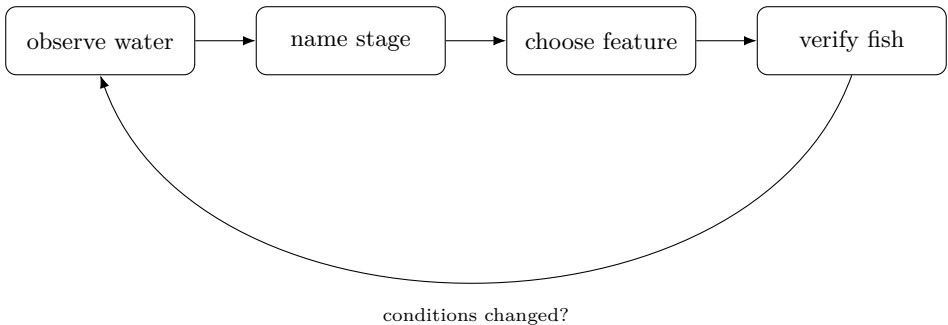


CALENDAR DOES NOT OPEN A SEASON

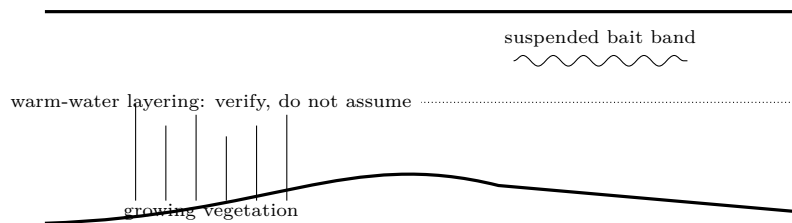
For 2026–27, resolve the exact water, species, and date in current Wisconsin DNR rules. No date, appearance, or reported thickness makes ice completely safe.

Use a loop, not a date



Period	Starting hypothesis	Evidence before committing
Ice-out / early spring	Protected shallows may warm first; pike and panfish may use emerging cover.	Repeatable temperature difference, green growth, bait, safe access, and legal season.
Late spring	Spawn/post-spawn movement can concentrate fish shallow.	Beds, recovering fish, water temperature; avoid damaging nests.
Early summer	Vegetation edges and hard-bottom breaks develop.	Actual weed-top and outside-edge depths, insect activity, repeated contact depth.
Mid-summer	Some fish use deep edges or suspend; oxygen can constrain depth.	Thermocline/oxygen evidence, bait height, and warm-water release risk.
Early fall	Cooling can redistribute forage and predators.	Turnover signs, temperature uniformity, wind, clarity change, and bait.
Late fall	Slow, depth-controlled presentations often help.	Repeated bottom contact, short feeding windows, cold-water protection.
Ice season	Vertical lures and tip-ups can cover lawful targets.	Current local ice assessment; avoid inlets, outlets, narrows, and pressure features.

Observable seasonal cross-section



Measurements to carry forward

Observation	Record so it can be compared
Surface temperature	Instrument, location, time, sun/wind, and sheltered versus windward difference; avoid false precision.
Plant stage	First green shoots, top depth, outside-edge depth, density, and whether hooks return clean.
Water column	Temperature/oxygen evidence if available; depth of bait and fish; never infer oxygen from depth alone.
Turnover candidate	Near-uniform temperature, mixed clarity/odor, dispersed bait, and changed bite together—not the calendar alone.
Ice condition	Direct local observations along the whole route; thickness at one hole never certifies an area.

Stage checks and first tests

Stage	Intermediate questions	Controlled first test
Warming shallows	Is it warmer on two readings? Is new cover present?	Compare one protected edge with adjacent main-lake water at equal depth.
Developed weeds	Where are inside, top, and outside edges today?	Fish 1 ft above the top, then the outside wall.
Layered summer	Is bait suspended? Is deep release responsible?	Hold at bait height; change target/location if fish show stress.
Cooling / turnover	Are temperatures actually converging? Has clarity changed?	Search multiple depths before slowing on a single feature.
Cold / ice	Can the route and return be made safely?	If uncertain, do not enter; fish open water only with cold-water boating protection.

Troubleshooting calendar errors

- **“They should be shallow.”** Measure temperature and cover; compare the next available depth rather than repeating the story.
- **“Turnover killed the bite.”** Seek multiple matching indicators; wind, turbidity, or presentation failure may look similar.
- **“The weeds are gone.”** Check deeper, shorter, and greener growth; surface dieback does not map the full plant bed.
- **“Ice was safe yesterday.”** Conditions and routes change. Reassess locally every trip; uncertainty is a stop condition.

Hypothesis passes when

Two or more observable indicators agree, the predicted feature can be located, and a controlled presentation can be repeated there. A catch strengthens the case; a calendar label never substitutes for evidence.

Field proof worksheet

Time / place	One action taken	Direct observation	Pass, fail, or next action
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Close the loop
Claim: What do I now think is true? _____
Evidence: What did I see, feel, measure, or repeat? _____
Fault ruled out: What alternative explanation did I check? _____
Next single action: What one change will test the claim? _____

Final proof

Do not mark complete because every written step was attempted. Mark complete only when the guide’s observable pass condition is present, the safety chain is intact, and another person could repeat the action from this record. If the result is ambiguous, record a fail and choose one corrective action.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR season dates, Hook Your Catch, and Ice Safety.

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